

What makes this idea worth investing in?

As I mentioned before, this topic is actually 10x more nuanced than it seems at first glance. There exists a lot of finger-wagging in the space of non-Indigenous researchers/builders working with Indigenous communities and Indigenous knowledge. Most of it is warranted; there have been a huge number of cases of researchers extracting/colonizing Indigenous knowledge without really doing anything in return, and that's why I'm starting by building the scaffolding of this project. This will a) show I know what I'm talking about, and that I'm immersed in the field, so that when I begin building I'm more credible and b) open up the plan for execution to all communities involved, ready for input. Because I really believe it's necessary and radical, but I can't make waves until I've shown I'll approach the whole thing with humility. That's why I've written a preliminary white paper outlining the project and what ethical and technical considerations need to be in place for it to work. I'm attaching it below if you're interested in understanding the project at a deeper level. This will grow into the main artifact for this summer, in which I'll describe the evals a future LLM should be using. The key thing here is that the building of the LLM is not the most important part — it's building the infrastructure. That infrastructure has the power to completely change the way we look at systems. Donella Meadows' *Leverage Points: Places to Intervene in a System* goes deeper into changing systems, and the idea is that this project aims to disrupt the system at the second highest order: in the "mindset or paradigm out of which the system — its goals, power structure, rules, its culture — arises."

I've been conducting research and interviews with leaders in the field since May/June — some notable people being Prof. Alan Blackwell, Amanda Joy Ravenhill, and Dr. Maui Hudson (who designed the actual principles for Indigenous data sovereignty!). I'm planning a virtual summit this fall to bring all these experts together. I also plan to keep working on this while in school, so naturally it'll be part time, but receiving the grant would let me scale this, pressure-test it, and work on it in all my free time.

[People sometimes ask — why Indigenous reasoning? Why not feminist AI? Or a pet AI? Or a Daoist AI? And honestly, those are all interesting questions. But to me, this project isn't just about exploring alternative worldviews for the sake of it — it's about choosing one that's especially *useful right now*. Indigenous reasoning systems are not only philosophically rich, they are inherently systems-based — emphasizing relationality, interdependence, and long-term responsibility.]

[I've grown up around conversations about climate — my dad works in that space — and I've seen firsthand how often mainstream solutions fail because they approach the planet as a set of resources, not relationships. What Indigenous frameworks offer is something deeper than sustainability: they offer a logic that reorients the system itself. That's what makes this the right starting point. It's not about checking boxes — it's about building systems that think differently, because our future depends on it.]

What my project shows is that Indigenous wisdom provides a new way of thinking. Instead of looking at it as a cultural artifact, it (at risk of sounding too extractive and for lack of better

words) should be utilized as a tool to further modern-day knowledge. Now, for the grant itself and how it would help me:

To host a conference

I want to host a convening by the end of 2025 bringing together ~20 leaders working with AI and Indigenous wisdom. I want this to be the place key conversations start to happen, the spark. I'd need ~\$6K for honoraria, marketing, outreach, etc. Now, the money will be critical, absolutely, but I'm almost more interested in...

The credibility + support

Given my age, it's not a surprise that I don't have the biggest network of intellectual and curious people. An EV grant would bring me massive credibility and support, and unlock a completely new network.

For Phase II

After the conference, using the new network and momentum I would launch Phase 2: a community-driven effort that uses the scaffolding I provide in my white paper. We put in place the year-long testimony collection I propose and we build a repository — we'll start out with a few hundred, and once we have those foundations, I'd hope to get to the thousands. Indigenous leaders will steward the project and eventually, with technical collaborators and Indigenous leaders co-developing, we'll utilize the repository to actually build the LLM.

This is a big and time-consuming project, but I've started to do real work, and plan to keep going, with the right people involved. I'd love your support.